

THREE ASPECTS THAT PREVENT MAN FROM LOVING

Greetings, my dearest, dearest friends. God bless you. Blessed is this hour.

When I offer these blessings, what does this word mean to you? Is this not often a mere word without meaning, without reality? Yet it is a very definite reality. If you were but free, really free of all your barriers, of all the layers that prevent you from feeling, from living, from experiencing to the fullest; these blessings would be a reality for you. You would feel the actual stream, the current of love that flows to each and every one of you from a world of light and freedom, from a world of harmony and truth, a world of love! But this stream of love is often unable to penetrate or reach you, to be perceived and experienced by you because the senses that are destined for such perceptions are dulled. They are dulled by your fears, shames, and urgent wishes, by your guards. All these fears, shames, unfulfilled needs, urgent wishes, and guards are based on error, confusion, misconception.

How often have I discussed this in our time together! But, again, too often my words become mere words you hear but do not truly understand and experience. They can be a reality only if and when you find their particular truth within yourself. And, my friends, this cannot be done by intellectual deductions and findings, but only when you allow yourself to feel, to live through your emotions and thereby determine the specific misconceptions you have harbored all your life. Awareness of your untruth brings you so much nearer to the love current coming to you from without, and to the love current within yourself.

Within each individual exists a well of wisdom and love. There is a treasure deep within that can come to the fore only as you become aware of all those aspects that barricade this treasure. You are accustomed to look for truth, guidance, solutions to your problems outside yourself -- perhaps through wise teachings, by means of a helping hand, or even for guidance that comes from outside yourself. But the most reliable and realistic answers come from inside yourself. In order to tap that well, outside help is necessary, but only if it finally succeeds in bringing you to this inner well.

Apart from this path of self-confrontation, is there an additional way to help you tap this well? Yes, there is. You have to seek calmness, outside and inside. Every day enter into a meditation whereby you become very still so that the inner noise covering this well makes itself precisely known to you. After translating this noise, such meditation will finally bring out of that well of wise guidance warm feelings of love and affection, of understanding for others, without your own urgent needs blurring out the realistic perception of others.

He who wants to disregard that inner noise (of fears, shames, guards, defenses, urgent needs), to by-pass it, and to come directly to the well of calmness will not really reach the inner treasure. He may think so, but this does not make it real. In relaxed openness, the momentary existence of the

barrier and the noise has to be acknowledged and then translated into meaning. That is the way, my friends. Such daily periods of becoming calm so as to determine the meaning of the barrier to the calm will help you greatly, and this practice most definitely must not be neglected.

We have discussed at length how harmful such barriers are for you. But the emphasis of our discussion in the past was on yourself and not so much on you in relationship to others. Yet, as I said so often and as you know very well, your unhappiness and confusion is always in connection with others, in connection with the difficulty of coping with your fellow creatures. Therefore we will now use the knowledge you have gained about yourself through your work on this path and apply it to your relationship with others.

When you calmly observe your reactions to others, you are bound to discover and become acutely aware of an inner tension, a cramped closing up. This prevents you from meeting others freely and openly, without restrictions and without inner tension. You cannot reach out without grabbing. You cannot expect without urgent demands. You cannot give out without fear. When you meet others in willingness to love, then and only then can your life be really fulfilled, no matter how worthy your various activities may be. The fear is always "but what about all these people who take advantage of such warm, loving feelings? If I do not guard myself and let myself feel, I will suffer." It is true that your inner well with its wise guidance, its reliable intuition cannot function when it is thickly covered. By covering it even more thickly through prohibiting feelings, you do not free that well that cannot lead you astray if it is unblocked. So the remedy must be sought by allowing the covering barriers to reach your conscious understanding.

In the absence of this profound communication with others, you are in isolation. You cannot possibly be happy. We have discussed many aspects which prevent this deep communication with others. Let us tonight discuss further three particular such aspects which constitute an inner no to loving. This inner no is not only due to fear of suffering hurt and disappointment; there are other aspects as well which have not been sufficiently discussed and which need deeper understanding.

The three aspects to be considered can be found in almost all human beings to some degree. Yet, one of the three points might be predominant, while the other two may be of lesser importance. Yet, no matter how little you feel at the moment that they apply to you, it is important that you look into yourself and closely watch your emotional reactions and then translate them. You are bound to find that one or the other or all of these aspects exist in you in various degrees of strength.

The first aspect is a fear that if you allow yourself to feel as you naturally tend to, you may be forced to do something you do not want to do; to sacrifice when you have no desire to do so; to give in when it is disadvantageous or inconvenient. You believe that the only way to safeguard yourself against the excessive and perhaps even childish demands of others is by curbing your natural feelings and thereby cutting off the love current from within. Conversely, you believe that if you were to allow yourself these natural feelings, you would be forced to give in. You do not see another alternative. Hence, in the misconception of seeing only these two alternatives, you undermine the organic process of emotional growth by manipulating your feelings in a most negative and destructive way with the gravest of repercussions on your psychic life and upon your relationship with others. To name but a few of such repercussions, one is a deep-seated guilt for this deliberate prohibition to loving; another is a subsequent lack of self-confidence and self-respect. The need to make up for it is often gratified by doing much more for others than one would

ordinarily do, and then really being taken advantage of as a consequence. Only, all this is done without love, as a substitute for the love withheld, and therefore the deeds do not remove the guilt. This proves once again how you cannot help but wind up in the very situation you strive to avoid when the means of avoidance are false, unrealistic, and based on wrong conclusions. All the emotions that stem from this misconception -- guilt, resentment for doing what you now do compulsively as a substitute for loving, lack of self-respect -- all these create confusion and make you incapable of coping with people in closer relationships. This produces the further result of your either being constantly involved in a most negative way or of withdrawing and living in bitter isolation, which in turn breeds frustration. These, then, are the barriers to your well of wisdom, love, intuition -- all of which give you the proper inner guidance.

But how is the situation when viewed with a truthful outlook? It is very possible, indeed, to love without having to fulfill every demand, without having to give in. Is it not better to be selfish if you wish to be, in deeds, while still loving and feeling? Is it not much better and actually much less selfish than doing everything possible without loving? It is much easier to assert your rights and wishes, whether they be right or wrong, selfish or unselfish, if you love. When you do not love, this self-assertion is very hard because your gnawing guilt either paralyzes you; or, if you manage to voice your objections, they will come out in a very hurting way. You cannot really hurt another because you refuse, provided you love. Disagreement and refusal no longer represent monsters you have to fight against. They become relaxed and easy and unproblematic. In your ability to love, you will feel yourself to be more lovable and will, therefore, be able to say "no" outwardly, because the inner "no" to loving and feeling has been removed.

All this does not mean that you artificially try to force love where it does not naturally exist. This would be useless, as you know. But detect that fine and subtle current, often at first quite covered up, in which you withdraw from your organic, natural feelings, stunting them deliberately, as it were. Once you come across this aspect, become more aware of it, you can then let it go free. In this knowledge, in understanding that the two alternatives are not the only ones, you will stop the prohibition and regain a new freedom with the most joyful, strengthening, and liberating results.

If there are no warm, loving feelings to begin with, just see what is there. You will find all the negative emotions under discussion. These have to be acknowledged and understood and not pushed away or suppressed. When you understand them sufficiently, the warm, natural feelings of affection are bound to come out eventually. For they are in you. They do not have to be given unto you from outside. They are only buried under the negative emotions which are the product of not allowing the productive emotions to come to fruition because you harbor a simple misunderstanding. Since this misunderstanding is not out in the open, it is not amenable to correction. This is why the misunderstanding has to be made known first. You have to see clearly why it is a misunderstanding. Then you can proceed. If you flow through the scale of feelings, truly experiencing them as they come up, you will probably go through the following sequences: the misunderstanding causes the deliberate cutting off of natural productive feeling. This, in turn, results in guilt, fear, uncertainty, anger, resentment, helpless rage, confused fluctuation between giving in too much and being too severe. All these feelings and confusions have to be fully experienced before you can actually feel the reality of the love in you.

First, it will manifest only occasionally, weakly, not dramatically. But when it does, be aware of it, let it, and see what a wonderful effect it has on you and on those about you. One of the effects

on others often will be that their excessive demands diminish the moment they sense a love current from you, even if you do not commit any deeds in connection with it. For their demands are often an unconscious, blind outlet for the love they seek. They themselves are too confused to realize that affection, understanding, love are much more important to them than what they demand. Their demands, in turn, are the substitute for what they really seek. Once this is given, the demands are bound to diminish in the ratio of the love you are genuinely capable of feeling.

The second aspect is this. As you know from our work in the past, almost everyone has a symbolic superior world that he wants to be accepted by, he wants to belong in. When this superior world happens to be seemingly unfeeling, undemonstrative, or even tough, you do not dare to let yourself feel that which you naturally feel, out of the fear of being despised by this superior world. This is especially strong when your natural warm feelings are directed towards someone you are convinced you should look down upon, according to the imagined, or real, standards of this superior world. Now, whether or not it is true that the people belonging in this world feel that way, the damage you do to yourself is, again, of the gravest consequences. Chances are that these very same people actually feel very differently from the way you think; that they would respect, like, and accept you much more if you were a kind and loving person who does not deny and betray the best in himself in order to get approval. They may not be aware of these reactions, but since the unconscious currents are a reality, their reaction would prove this to be so. You are bound to find this out, but only when you have the courage to be yourself. For some, it takes much more courage to be themselves in their loving selves than it would take to be their self-assertive "strong" selves.

But let us suppose the superior world of your aspirations is actually the way you think it is. Does this not mean that their representatives are just as immature in this respect as you are? To emulate such immaturity cannot ever produce self-respect and certainty in your personality. All it can do is create self-contempt and guilt. It must rob you of the firm ground under your feet that only being yourself can grant. To simulate a pseudostrength by the denial of loving and by the betrayal of your real self at the expense of the apparent weaker ones, whom you are supposed to reject and despise, produces the same self-hate as is produced when a person lacks courage and strength and self-assertion, and when he submits in evident weakness. This pseudostrength is, in reality and essence, just as weak as submitting. You who belong in this category submit for the sake of approval by denying the best in you. You deliberately set up a process of self-alienation in the simple act of discouraging your natural warm feelings, and artificially producing toughness.

Again, all this is not conscious thought. You may not be at all aware of these inner processes, but if you look closely at some of your reactions, you may well discover that this holds true for you. Or perhaps you are aware of it already to some degree, but have never quite thought about it in these terms. To do so, to carry the significance of these reactions further, is bound to give you a more comprehensive view about it, and thus to change these very childish attitudes. When you thus have the courage to be true to your real self, even if it loves a person "the superior world" decrees you are to despise, you will discover that the whole division of a "superior world" and an "inferior world" is an illusion. This discovery will set you free and give you a strength such as you cannot envision now.

For those of you who have not delved into some depth of your being, what I say here might sound rather far-fetched or even silly. But for some of my friends, these words will be a reality and will help them to dissolve some very crippling misunderstandings about life and people.

The third aspect of the inner "no" against loving may at first sound paradoxical. People who predominantly have this aspect have such a great need for fulfillment and love that nonfulfillment presents a special fear and threat. Their remedy is a strong forcing current. Needless to say, this remedy is, again, unproductive, even destructive. The forcing current prohibits a free love-giving. In its own devious way, it causes an inner "no" to giving in a relaxed and calm way. It grabs and demands. Yes, the person wants to give, but does so compulsively in order to have his demands fulfilled -- not wisely and in sensitive awareness of what the other needs and wants. Therefore the giving is not free nor genuine.

This category is often on the "other side of the fence," so to speak, from the first category that I discussed. They often get into conflict with one another. The demands and the forcing current frighten away the other one even if these demands parade under the guise of "giving."

The one who is so starved and therefore terrified by refusal must be blind to others. All he feels is his own need. He has no room and no calmness to look truly at the other person and sense the other's needs. Refusal is so devastating that he courts it by his urgency. When it comes, all he experiences is the confirmation of his own worthlessness. This distorted view prohibits a true evaluation of the situation in question. His own worthlessness has nothing to do with his defeat. The other person's fears and problems may be as responsible for it as his own blindness to see the world and others only in terms of his worth or lack of it, and the subsequent powerful forcing current employed to dispel the dreaded worthlessness.

The realistic remedy for the person who belongs predominantly in this category is, broadly speaking, to face his lack of belief in himself and find out the real reasons -- such as his lack of loving, which is often disguised by an overeagerness to give for the purpose of receiving the love as a child wants to be loved; to find all the distorted concepts and to understand why they are distorted; to allow himself to experience all the feelings as they come up in the process of this self-search. Chances are that underneath the conscious urgent need, he will find some reason for prohibiting his real feelings for affection and loving. This may be so hidden that, offhand, he may deny it utterly. All he feels is his need to be loved, which he confuses with genuine feelings of affection for others. The latter is a much less urgent, much calmer emotion, and is not at all self-centered as the need is. Again, these mature feelings exist, but they have been prohibited from developing, and this point has to be made conscious. A second remedy is to face that repeated unfulfillment hurts so much more than it needs to hurt because of a childish inability to stand frustration. Before fulfillment can come, the various points as to his lack of belief in himself, as outlined above, have to be followed through.

This takes time. In the course of this, more disappointments may come. But now they can be utilized for the work and serve as wonderful means for discovering more about the self. In the meantime, what one can, in full awareness, learn simultaneously is to swing with the tide, not to resist it by a wild struggling of soul forces. Thus the maturity will come in teaching the soul to be able to stand frustration without repression or anger. This has the healing effect of bringing the pendulum into a more balanced position. From an overactivity (the forcing current, the wild struggling), a serenity is generated which brings the person closer to the state of being.

It cannot be emphasized strongly enough that all the frustrated emotions causing the urgency and the starvation have to be allowed to simmer on the surface and have to be translated into meaning and thereby into understanding. In this person, another reaction exists that also has to be brought to awareness and faced. When sometimes the needs are fulfilled, the "love" wears off. This should furnish the proof that what he thought was love is not love but starving need -- certainly a great difference! In this connection is the fact that this person is as incapable of fulfilling other people's needs as those belonging to the former category. He backs away from them and feels infringed upon by them just as the others do. Recognition of this fact is of primary importance. In this hidden countercurrent, he is just as afraid to let down his guards as are the others; only this fear is covered up by the manifest need and the fear of nonfulfillment.

All he can see is what he wants or what he fears will come into being -- nothing else. He is torn between these two alternatives, interpreting every outer happening into either the one or the other alternative. In neither alternative does he see the reality.

Now, my friends, this is food for thought and material for your further work, for each and every one of you. I venture to say that with most people a combination of all these three aspects exists in some way; but with many, one aspect is quite obvious and not difficult to verify. There is no one here, or no one reading these words, for whom one of these aspects is not immediately applicable. If you work with it, you cannot help but register further results. These lectures are destined to the levels of your being where such irrational attitudes exist. They are not addressed to your rational thinking.

And now, my friends, let us turn to your questions.

QUESTION: Can you elaborate on the difference between pity and compassion? As one gets older and sees so many of one's friends suffering, what is the proper attitude?

ANSWER: I will be glad to give additional help in this question if I can, although this topic was repeatedly discussed in the past. However, if I were to say what the right feeling should be in theory, it would not help you at all. All you would then do would be to further manipulate your feelings and superimpose attitudes that are not genuinely yours. You know that this cannot possibly be a healthy procedure; rather it is important for you to acknowledge what you really feel, whether right or wrong. In addition to what I said generally about the difference between pity and compassion, I now want to present an explanation indicating why one feels pity instead of the so much more productive feeling of compassion. Whenever you are crushed by this devastating emotion of pity, which prohibits your strength and therefore the help you can give, you can be quite sure that you are somewhere involved: for instance, a projection of your fear that the fate that the other suffers may come to you, or that you feel guilty about something you may not be aware of. A very universal facet in this respect is that the person feels a certain satisfaction at the other's mishap. A satisfaction not only that he himself does not have to bear that fate, but also that the other is punished and has difficulties. This is of course entirely irrational, but the attitude consists of considerations such as this: "If others have hardship too, I am not so bad. I am not the only one who suffers. Therefore I am glad that others suffer too." This reaction produces such shock and guilt that it is entirely repressed and overcompensated for by a weakening, unproductive pity. In this pity, the person then feels absolved because he suffers with the other person, but in a destructive way.

If you can discover and feel through these original reactions, accepting the fact that you are a mere human being with many unpurified emotions, with many childish, selfish, shortsighted attitudes, and you learn to do so without condemning or condoning or justifying yourself, then you can learn to understand what is behind these unreasonable attitudes. And thereby they will gradually, little by little, in the measure that you truly understand them, dissolve. Pity will transform into compassion, and therefore constructive help will be possible, whether it can be given through certain actions or just by feeling.

QUESTION: In the past, you discussed the close connection between cause and effect. Are we then to believe that we are living in a world of causality where identical effects stem from identical causes?

ANSWER: Of course, this is a world of causality. As for the identical causes producing identical effects, that depends on what exactly you mean by identical. What may appear like two identical causes may, in reality, not be identical at all. The act may be the same, but the two individuals are different. Let us take a crass example like murder. Let us assume that two people commit murder, even for the same motive. Yet the background that led to these feelings, that led to this action as well as their overall development, as well as all their personality and character traits, may be different from one another. Their reactions after the act may not be identical. Therefore the effect -- not necessarily the outer effect, but the effect upon the two individuals in question -- may not be at all identical.

But if you mean that this law of cause and effect is to the finest detail an organic, infinitely just and harmonious process, a balancing factor in the entire universe, so exact in its workings that error or injustice is utterly impossible, in that sense identical causes stem from identical effects.

Why it should be so hard to accept for man that he lives in a world of causality is not easy to understand. When he really looks at the world and the events in it, he is constantly confronted with the living reality of cause and effect. With the smallest daily issues, cause and effect operate, but he is so used to it, it is so much part of his daily life, that he takes it for granted. He has lost the ability to see it with the newness that is necessary in order to derive deeper understanding out of it. Were man able to see what constantly happens, it would not be so difficult for him to realize that the same law must exist also in wider issues. He would not feel any reason to assume that a different law operates merely because in one instance cause and effect are close together, while in other issues they are separated by time. Time has no bearing on it. It only has bearing on disclosing the cause or the effect to you. Sometimes man can see both. Sometimes he can see only one or the other. If man would think logically to the very end of this phenomenon, he would realize that his ability to see either cause or effect does not change the fact that they are interdependent.

When you sufficiently uncover cause and effect in your personal life, what is called faith and what is really an experience of a truth comes into being. Then it is no longer a question of superimposing doctrines or postulates. Various happenings and results have puzzled you so far for which you saw no cause. By getting to know yourself better, you discover the causes for many effects. You discover them as an indisputable fact. This gives you not only freedom and strength, but it also shows you the causality in its true light. You then know that the same law of causality

must hold true also where you cannot know the causes -- be it with your own life, be it with others, be it with the world, with creation, in general.

My dearest friends, may these words fall on fruitful soil. May you all come a tiny little step closer to seeing your own barriers. For that is the most constructive step towards removing them. The human error always lies in the fact that man wants to deny the barrier's existence, thus pushing against it, thus only strengthening it. He wants to remove it without seeing what that barrier really is. But even once he becomes aware of it, understands its components, he realizes that it cannot be pushed away by force. It can dissolve only gradually in the measure that this barrier is ever better understood.

Again a warm stream and current of love is reaching towards each one of you. Make yourself inwardly calm. Detect your fears, your guards, your shames, your embarrassment, your resistance against feelings. And as you do so, this stream will be able to reach you much better. It will send some aspect of its force into your hearts, where it will fill you with a light, a strength, a hope. Be in peace, be in God!

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